

Devil In the Details: The Decision to Drop the Atomic Bomb

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Introduction

On August 6, 1945, the world witnessed the use of the ultimate weapon under the pretext of bringing an end to the deadliest conflict in human history. This weapon was, of course, the atomic bomb, dropped on Hiroshima and Nagasaki, marking the end of World War II. Its use ushered in a new age of atomic power, defined by the nations that possessed nuclear capabilities and those that did not. However, more than just a military turning point, the decision to deploy the bomb led to the abrupt loss of approximately 250,000 Japanese lives.¹ Among these were the lives of children, women, the elderly, and countless non-combatants. In an instant, they were reduced to ash and bone, a tragic consequence of a single decision made by one man, President Truman, who held the fate of nearly a quarter of a million lives in his hands.

However, had Truman declined to pursue atomic means to end the war, it's possible that the conflict would have continued longer than in the timeline where he chose to drop the bomb. This would likely have meant more American lives lost, as well as potentially more Japanese lives, needlessly sacrificed due to the President's inaction. Remember that this was a total war, where "in 1944 and probably earlier, Germany's complete defeat was inevitable. But the German surrender did not occur until May 1945."² This was a war in which the only terms of surrender were present in the Potsdam Declaration, and it demanded unconditional surrender.³ All of this together, the magnitude and intensity of the situation, forces the American decision to drop the atomic bombs to be one of the most critical decisions of the twentieth century. The nuclear bombs changed the world both physically, with lasting radiation effects, and historically, by

¹Frank Barnaby, "The Effects of the Atomic Bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki," *Medicine and War* 11, no. 3 (July 1995): 1–9, <https://doi.org/10.1080/07488009508409217>. Pp 2.

²Gar Alperovitz, Robert L. Messer, and Barton J. Bernstein, "Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb," *International Security* 16, no. 3 (1991): 204, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539092>. Pp 13.

³ Gar Alperovitz, Robert L. Messer, and Barton J. Bernstein, "Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb," *International Security* 16, no. 3 (1991): 204, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539092>. Pp 14.

ushering in the Cold War era and officially ending the Second World War. Thus, the question is, should President Truman have authorized the dropping of the atomic bomb

There were multiple avenues through which the Americans could have concluded the war in the Pacific, each with its own set of debates and challenges. The two main options were either to decline the use of atomic bombs and pursue other means to end the war or to proceed as President Truman did in our timeline. Other options include changing the conditions of the Potsdam declaration, continuing the suffocation of Japan's home islands through naval and aerial means, or potentially launching a conventional invasion, among others. However, since there are so many potential alternatives to the atomic bombs' role in ending the war, limits must be placed. First, the hypothetical invasion of Japan, Operation Downfall, will not be considered, as the circumstances surrounding this option are too speculative, with too many unknown variables, such as potential casualty figures. All that will be regarded in the invasion scenario is that it would have caused more American casualties than the other methods. This is due to amphibious landings, in general, being a deadly affair. Second, no consideration will be given to arguments involving Soviet actions or influence, as the decision to drop the atomic bombs was an American one, made solely by the President, the top brass of the American armed forces, and his advisors.

Altogether, this leaves the two main arguments in the debate. On the side of those in favor of detonation, the peace-resistant stance of the Japanese high command forced President Truman to take extreme measures to convince key members of that command that surrender was the only viable option, and that doing so quickly and with the least damage to the American side was the best course of action. On the side of anti-detonation, the argument against using atomic bombs on Japan suggests that Japan was already on the brink of surrender and that altering the demand for unconditional surrender might have led to peace. Continued naval blockades and

military pressure were crippling Japan's war effort, risking famine and further strain. Given these conditions, critics argue that Japan would have surrendered before reaching a breaking point, making the use of atomic bombs unnecessary. Together, these arguments make up the basis for the dialectic and provide two of the key corners of the atomic bomb debate.

A. The Orthodox Stance: The Argument for Detonation

Three authors are on the side in favor of the detonation of the atomic bombs. Those authors are: Robert P. Newman in *'Ending the War with Japan: Paul Nitze's "Early Surrender" Counterfactual'*, Sadao Asada in *'The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan's Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration'*, and Christopher Clary with *'The Starvation Myth: the U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II'*. These authors represent the orthodox side of the debate, supporting President Truman's decision and the use of atomic bombs. They argue that alternative actions, such as those proposed to President Truman as substitutes for the bombs, would have prolonged the war unnecessarily. Key reasons for this include the lack of shock value provided by conventional measures, the resilience of the Japanese military high command, Japan's ability to sustain itself for at least another six months through its production, and the over-reliance of revisionist arguments on the flawed United States Strategic Bombing Survey (USSBS) report.

Starting with Robert P. Newman's article, the primary point that is being made is the general unreliability that stems from the USSBS reports and its main conductor, Paul Nitze. Within this report lies one of the main standings of the revisionist argument, which is that President Truman knew that the war was over and used the atomic bombs as a means to intimidate the Soviet Union.⁴ This is supported by the fact that the summary report states, "The Survey's opinion that certainly before December 31, 1945, and in all probability before

⁴Robert P. Newman, "Ending the War with Japan: Paul Nitze's 'Early Surrender' Counterfactual," *Pacific Historical Review* 64, no. 2 (May 1, 1995): 167–94, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3640894>. Pp 167.

November 1, 1945, Japan would have surrendered even if the atomic bombs had not been dropped, even if Russia had not entered the war, and even if no invasion had been planned or contemplated”.⁵ Thus, in this supposedly non-partisan report, it should have shut out any arguments of the contrary and shown that the atomic bombs were both unjust and unneeded. However, this was not the case as Newman started to look more deeply into the methods that were used to create such a survey which was primarily from testimony from high-ranking Japanese officials who survived after the war had concluded.⁶ The first issue when considering this method is that the Japanese officials would be more favoring towards both the Emperor and also the Americans, as they would want to appease their current overlords.⁷ The second issue is the fact that out of all the high-ranking officials who testified, only Kōichi Kido, Lord Keeper of the Privy Seal of Japan, testified, stating that the war would have ended early with or without the bomb or the invasion from the Soviets.⁸ Yet, this is even debatable as he would also go on at the Tokyo trials and state that the atomic bombs were "a great shock to the nation, together with the Soviet Union's participation in the Pacific War.... I thought there would be no course left but to broadcast an Imperial rescript to the nation...terminating the war”.⁹

The next point from the pro-detonation side of the aisle is the fact that the blockade, which was perceived as another means to reach surrender, was not as effective as once thought. This argument is primarily covered by Christopher Clary with ‘*The Starvation Myth: the U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II*. Within his article, he discusses the primary arguments made

⁵Robert P. Newman, “Ending the War with Japan: Paul Nitze’s ‘Early Surrender’ Counterfactual,” *Pacific Historical Review* 64, no. 2 (May 1, 1995): 167–94, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3640894>. Pp 167.

⁶Robert P. Newman, “Ending the War with Japan: Paul Nitze’s ‘Early Surrender’ Counterfactual,” *Pacific Historical Review* 64, no. 2 (May 1, 1995): 167–94, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3640894>. Pp 174.

⁷Robert P. Newman, “Ending the War with Japan: Paul Nitze’s ‘Early Surrender’ Counterfactual,” *Pacific Historical Review* 64, no. 2 (May 1, 1995): 167–94, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3640894>. Pp 174.

⁸Robert P. Newman, “Ending the War with Japan: Paul Nitze’s ‘Early Surrender’ Counterfactual,” *Pacific Historical Review* 64, no. 2 (May 1, 1995): 167–94, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3640894>. Pp 180.

⁹Robert P. Newman, “Ending the War with Japan: Paul Nitze’s ‘Early Surrender’ Counterfactual,” *Pacific Historical Review* 64, no. 2 (May 1, 1995): 167–94, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3640894>. Pp 181.

by both the revisionist and orthodox sides of the aisle with notes on the inconsistency that plagued both the Truman administration and the USSBS.¹⁰ However, the main thing of note that he brings up is the condition of the agricultural sector within Japan. Clary states that “before the very end of 1945, things were going fairly well for Japanese agriculture. Even in 1945, when every perceivable stress had been placed on the Japanese, the situation was such that they probably could have sustained themselves for another six months to a year”.¹¹ This in itself would mean that under solely a blockade and bombing campaign, the war would have continued well into 1946 which would have been against the wishes of both the American people and their president. Furthermore, Clary goes into the *Japanese Wartime Standard of Living and Utilization of Manpower* portion of the USSBS survey which talks about the fluctuations in the economy and the impacts the war had on the standard of living.

Within his analysis, he found that in the pre-war years, Japan imported 20% of its caloric needs, and during the end of the war, that would drop to 9%.¹² While creating some hardship, this decrease would not have caused mass starvation as described in the USSB. Rather, the Japanese government would counter this decline through scavenging programs such as processing “150 million acorns” and stockpiling basic goods before the full enforcement of the blockade.^{13 14} Altogether, Clary makes the point that while there was hardship felt by the Japanese population, it wasn’t enough to warrant a surrender, especially before the end of 1945.

¹⁰Christopher Clary, “The Starvation Myth: The U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II,” Fairmount Folio: Journal of History, April 19, 2016, <https://journals.wichita.edu/index.php/ff/article/view/62>. Pp 126.

¹¹Christopher Clary, “The Starvation Myth: The U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II,” Fairmount Folio: Journal of History, April 19, 2016, <https://journals.wichita.edu/index.php/ff/article/view/62>. Pp 127.

¹²Christopher Clary, “The Starvation Myth: The U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II,” Fairmount Folio: Journal of History, April 19, 2016, <https://journals.wichita.edu/index.php/ff/article/view/62>. Pp 128.

¹³Christopher Clary, “The Starvation Myth: The U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II,” Fairmount Folio: Journal of History, April 19, 2016, <https://journals.wichita.edu/index.php/ff/article/view/62>. Pp 131.

¹⁴Christopher Clary, “The Starvation Myth: The U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II,” Fairmount Folio: Journal of History, April 19, 2016, <https://journals.wichita.edu/index.php/ff/article/view/62>. Pp 133.

The final author present is Sadao Asada in *'The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan's Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration'*, who primarily talks about the unwillingness of the Japanese to surrender. Initially, Asada makes the key distinction that both the Japanese and Americans knew that Japan was militarily defeated, but the difference in judgment comes from the fact that, while defeated, it did not surrender.¹⁵ The issue of surrender was one that many in the military found unacceptable, and they preferred to exhaust the Americans in a defense battle of the home islands. Not only that, but there were multiple doubts from the Japanese Army on if there truly was an atomic bomb dropped on Hiroshima and if the United States even had more.¹⁶ However, this opinion wasn't shared with those who remained in the civilian government, such as Foreign Minister Togo, who believed that with the advent of the atomic bombing of Hiroshima, the war needed to be terminated as soon as possible.

This was a sentiment shared by Emperor Hirohito, according to Togo. he said, "Now that such a new weapon has appeared, it has become less possible to continue the war...So my wish is to make such arrangements as will end the war as soon as possible".¹⁸ This sentiment wasn't echoed by the top brass as they were too busy adding conditions towards unconditional peace such as "that there be no military occupation of the homeland by the Allies...that the armed forces be allowed to disarm and demobilize themselves...that war criminals be prosecuted by the Japanese government", in an attempt to save their skin from war crime trials.¹⁹ Thus, with a

¹⁵Sadao Asada, "The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan's Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration," *Pacific Historical Review* 67, no. 4 (November 1, 1998): 477–512, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3641184>. Pp 479.

¹⁶ Sadao Asada, "The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan's Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration," *Pacific Historical Review* 67, no. 4 (November 1, 1998): 477–512, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3641184>. Pp 488.

¹⁷ Sadao Asada, "The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan's Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration," *Pacific Historical Review* 67, no. 4 (November 1, 1998): 477–512, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3641184>. Pp 491.

¹⁸ Sadao Asada, "The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan's Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration," *Pacific Historical Review* 67, no. 4 (November 1, 1998): 477–512, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3641184>. Pp 477.

¹⁹ Sadao Asada, "The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan's Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration," *Pacific Historical Review* 67, no. 4 (November 1, 1998): 477–512, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3641184>. Pp 493

stalwart military that was unrealizing peace, the dual shocks of the atomic bombs were seen as a way to help “the peace party were assisted by the atomic bomb in our endeavor to end the war”.²⁰

Asada further explains that not only did it help advance the cause of the civilian government’s calls for peace, it also helped the military save face as no matter what they could have done, they could have pointed to the fact that they were just going to get atomically bombarded into annihilation.²¹ Altogether, the shock and devastation that was present from the magnitude of the atomic bombs allowed the Japanese to save face and surrender in a way that other military operations wouldn’t have allowed, especially in such a short time.

B. The Revisionist Stance: A Case for Other Means of Surrender

On the contradicting side of this argument is the revisionist. This includes Gar Alperovitz and Robert L. Messer with “*Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb*” and Sheldon Garon with “*Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan*”. Together, they construct the following argument, which states: The Japanese War effort was destroyed, and its high command was on the verge of peace. This peace could have come from a continued blockade under Operation Starvation or a changing of conditions of the Potsdam Declaration. Yet, neither of these options was chosen. Rather, the President and his cabinet, particularly Secretary of War Henry L. Stimson, pursued an unnecessary strategy with a lack of in-depth consideration of the vast options that were at their disposal.

Starting with Gar Alperovitz and Robert L. Messer’s article, “*Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb*”, their primary topic is that the atomic bombs were considered part

²⁰ Sadao Asada, “The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan’s Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration,” *Pacific Historical Review* 67, no. 4 (November 1, 1998): 477–512, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3641184>. Pp 497.

²¹ Sadao Asada, “The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan’s Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration,” *Pacific Historical Review* 67, no. 4 (November 1, 1998): 477–512, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3641184>. Pp 508.

of the plan to get Japan to surrender in nearly every situation, even though there was ample evidence of a conditional peace. The authors gather this conclusion by sifting through the testimonies and diaries of those who helped make the decision or were in a position of power to know of the decisions made by the American government. Within these documents, it was obvious that there were clear options that could have supplanted the use of the bomb. This is shown when Samuel Walker, chief historian of the U.S. Nuclear Regulatory Commission, states, “consensus among scholars is that the bomb was not needed to avoid an invasion of Japan.... It is clear that alternatives to the bomb existed and that Truman and his advisers knew it”.²² The authors continue with their analysis and conclude that many in the upper echelons of the American Government knew that a Soviet entry would have been decisive enough, so much so that it was used as a backup in case an atomic bomb malfunctioned.^{23 24}

As for a conditioned peace, the authors provide sufficient evidence on both sides showing a potential willingness to forgo unconditional surrender. From the Japanese side, there is communication between Foreign Minister Sato and Prime Minister Hideki Tojo which stated, “It was all there, as clear as crystal: Tojo to Sato: 'Unconditional surrender is the only obstacle to peace’”.²⁵ This sentiment, of forgoing unconditional surrender for a quicker end to the war, was mirrored by Truman and Stimson. Together, they believed if the condition of letting Emperor Hirohito stay on the throne would have led to a quicker conclusion to war, then it would have been acceptable.²⁶ Altogether, the authors find that the failure to pursue diplomatic alternatives,

²²Gar Alperovitz, Robert L. Messer, “Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb,” *International Security* 16, no. 3 (1991): 204, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539092>. Pp 205.

²³Gar Alperovitz, Robert L. Messer, “Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb,” *International Security* 16, no. 3 (1991): 204, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539092>. Pp 206-207.

²⁴Gar Alperovitz, Robert L. Messer, “Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb,” *International Security* 16, no. 3 (1991): 204, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539092>. Pp 209.

²⁵ Gar Alperovitz, Robert L. Messer, “Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb,” *International Security* 16, no. 3 (1991): 204, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539092>. Pp 208.

²⁶Gar Alperovitz, Robert L. Messer, “Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb,” *International Security* 16, no. 3 (1991): 204, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539092>. Pp 210.

such as a conditional surrender, and the emphasis on the use of the atomic bomb, caused other avenues to potentially end the war to be fruitless.

Two of those strategies were blockading and bombardment as a means to wear down the Japanese nation. This method came under the name Operation Starvation, and Sheldon Garon discusses the merit it had in being a strategy to force Japan to submit. Garon starts this argument by discussing the state of the empire in terms of self-sufficiency, which was failing. This is proven by the fact that the empire had “experienced bad rice harvests during the latter half of 1939, due to flooding in Taiwan and record drought in Korea and Japan”.²⁷ This subsequently forced Japan to rely on its other colonies, such as Southeast Asia, as a means of meeting the home island’s caloric needs with 65% of its rice coming from Southeast Asia.²⁸ However, at the same time, this creates a vulnerability where if Japanese shipping lanes were under threat, then the rest of the empire would be lacking in not only food but also “oil, bauxite, tin, rubber, tungsten, and other raw materials”.²⁹

Furthermore, the blockade extended to the diplomatic front as the United States pressured Pacific nations to cease trade with Japan so that they wouldn’t have a situation of neutral nations shipping critical resources to Japan.³⁰ With Japan unable to gain resources from the rest of its empire or friendly nations, they turned to Chinese cereals and ultimately gave up importing critical war supplies like iron and coal in favor of domestic food supplies as cuts in hundreds of

²⁷Garon, Sheldon. 2024. “Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan.” *The International History Review* 46 (4): Pp 542.

²⁸Garon, Sheldon. 2024. “Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan.” *The International History Review* 46 (4): Pp 542.

²⁹Garon, Sheldon. 2024. “Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan.” *The International History Review* 46 (4): Pp 542.

³⁰Garon, Sheldon. 2024. “Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan.” *The International History Review* 46 (4): Pp 542.

calories plagued the Japanese population.³¹ This would only get worse as the war continued, with the amount of food entering Japan by early August reaching nearly zero.³²

The blockade's impact didn't stop at simply calories but wartime production as these workers needed sufficient calories to keep up productivity. This drop can be seen through the USSBS where political leaders and industrialists assert that "workers had become too malnourished and distracted to maintain production" and "that the blockade had been the Allies' most effective tactic in ending the war".³³

Altogether, Garon concludes this analysis by stating that there were too many things going on at once to persuade the Japanese leadership to surrender, and thus, within our timeline, it is unknown how much the blockade weighed on the Japanese mind. However, the author believes that if the Soviet intervention and atomic bombs had not occurred, then the Japanese leadership would not have lasted long against a blockade. Especially if the estimates made by Japanese industrialists of nearly seven million dead from starvation within a year became a reality.³⁴

In conclusion, the revisionist arguments presented by Alperovitz, Messer, and Garon challenge the traditional narrative of Japan's unconditional surrender by highlighting the overlooked alternatives to the atomic bomb, such as the potential for a conditional peace or the continued effectiveness of the U.S. blockade. By examining primary sources, including diplomatic communications and the findings of the USSBS, they reveal that Japan's leadership was already seeking peace and that alternatives to the bomb could have brought about an earlier

³¹Garon, Sheldon. 2024. "Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan." *The International History Review* 46 (4): Pp 544.

³²Garon, Sheldon. 2024. "Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan." *The International History Review* 46 (4): Pp 544.

³³Garon, Sheldon. 2024. "Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan." *The International History Review* 46 (4): Pp 545.

³⁴Garon, Sheldon. 2024. "Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan." *The International History Review* 46 (4): Pp 546.

end to the war. Their analysis suggests that a combination of diplomatic efforts and strategic military pressure, rather than the use of atomic weapons, may have sufficed to bring the conflict to a close.

C. Evaluation of the Orthodox Stance

Going in order in which they were introduced, we start out with Robert P. Newman's analysis of the USSBS. The criticality of the survey on which a lot of literature is based stresses the importance of this evaluation. Starting with Newman's sources, they are varied and numerous. This includes direct quotes from both the USSBS and the work of its founder, Paul Nitze, to direct statements that were conducted from interviews about the USSBS. These provide an ample basis for which Newman's analysis can stand as directly quoting the primary source for which you are criticizing, showing that the criticism that is being made isn't coming from an afterthought. After pulling these sources and analyzing them, Newman found that many of the interviews on which the USSBS is based contradict its findings and conclusion. As previously mentioned, only Kōichi Kido supported the claim that the Japanese would have surrendered without a Soviet Intervention or the dropping of the atomic bombs. A statement that Newman discredits by pulling another account where Kido states otherwise during the Tokyo trials. This could have been due to the Japanese and German tendency to essentially tell lies to appease the winning side of the Second World War.

Nonetheless, Newman's analysis was one of the best presented within this dialectic and had ample evidence not to entirely disregard but also create concern on the validity of this report which was supposed to be impartial. While there is some failure within the article in addressing the cause of bias that Nitze himself holds, the overall conclusion still reigns true but in a cloudy

state. There are questions made on why Nitze would have pushed so hard on discrediting the impact that both the atomic bombs and the Soviet invasion had on the Japanese surrender.

The second source was analyzed by Christopher Clary and was about the shortcomings of Operation Starvation and the ill-conceived notion that the blockade would have ended the war. The primary sources used here were from the USSBS, Nitze, and occasionally Newman. The reason for the latter two is due to Clary believing that “Nitze's account contains numerous important facts...difficult to believe that Nitze's data was precise enough to warrant a date by which the Japanese would probably have surrendered. When examining the data used by the USSBS, it is frequently inconclusive”.³⁵ Thus, there should be criticism of using data that is known to be infrequent and inconclusive, leading to an argument of cherry-picking statistics. The same argument plagues other debates surrounding the atomic bombs, such as the number of casualties that would have been produced from things such as Operation Downfall. With that in mind, there is a consensus that maritime shipping was on the downturn, and the blockade in itself was successful in limiting the amount of resources coming into Japan. This comes from multiple figures that show decreased merchant tonnage and the amount of food being imported: “from 1931 to 1940 19 percent of Japan's food supply, on a caloric basis, was imported”, being consistent from both sides of the argument.³⁶ Thus, while there should be warranted skepticism on the accuracy of these reports based on them coming from the USSBS, the general use of them on both sides of the aisle should calm some fears of inaccuracy.

As for the analysis, the idea of which widespread hunger would have caused surrender doesn't hold much merit. While hunger and hardship could lead to eventual civilian unrest and

³⁵Christopher Clary, “The Starvation Myth: The U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II,” *Fairmount Folio: Journal of History*, April 19, 2016, <https://journals.wichita.edu/index.php/ff/article/view/62>. Pp 128.

³⁶Christopher Clary, “The Starvation Myth: The U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II,” *Fairmount Folio: Journal of History*, April 19, 2016, <https://journals.wichita.edu/index.php/ff/article/view/62>. Pp 129.

the collapse of the war effort, it isn't guaranteed. An example of the contrary is the Turnip Winter in 1917 Germany where food shortages did cause malnutrition and cases of starvation due to the British blockade. However, the war continued for another year, and even then, alternative forms of caloric intake were found.³⁷ The same outcome was being found within Japan through stockpiling and acorns.³⁸ This means that their conclusion that the blockade by itself wouldn't have concluded with a surrender from the Japanese would ring true, even though the sources from which that conclusion is made are inconsistent.

The final source of the orthodox argument was from Sadao Asada, who argued that the atomic bombs helped produce a surrender by both boosting the peace party of the Japanese cabinet and helping the Japanese army save face. Their sources primarily come from memoirs and diaries of high-ranking Japanese officials. The first argument does have a base to stand upon as there are previously stated quotes showing the support of the atomic bomb within the peace party in the effort to use its shock value to crack military hardliners. This aligns with the second argument as the idea of going out in a final assault becomes distant when the enemy can simply launch an atomic barrage rather than launching an amphibious landing. However, while the logic of this argument does line up. The reality of what happened is different. Instead of hardliners converting after the atomic bombs, the council that was supposed to decide on unconditional surrender or not continued to be tied until Emperor Hirohito broke that tie.³⁹ Thus, the analysis here that the military would be able to save face does not concede to the reality that unfolded.

D. Evaluation of the Revisionist Stance

³⁷Geoffrey J. Giles, "The Great War and Urban Life in Germany: Freiburg, 1914–1918," *The Journal of Modern History* 81, no. 3 (September 2009): 728–30, <https://doi.org/10.1086/649114>. Pp 1.

³⁸Christopher Clary, "The Starvation Myth: The U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II," *Fairmount Folio: Journal of History*, April 19, 2016, <https://journals.wichita.edu/index.php/ff/article/view/62>. Pp 131.

³⁹Jean Senat Fleury, *Pacific War* (S.l.: LAP LAMBERT ACADEMIC PUBL, 2023). Pp 33

The argument on the part of the Revisionist Stance is that the atomic bomb's deployment could have been avoided through the means of a continued blockade under Operation Starvation or a changing of conditions of the Potsdam Declaration. This stance started with Gar Alperovitz and Robert L. Messer's article, which argued that there was a failure on the part of the American leadership to consider the possibility of a surrender that didn't include the detonation of the atomic bombs over inhabited areas. The evidence came from the National Archives, particularly President Truman's *'Potsdam Diary'* which allowed the authors to gain insight into the decision-making of the American leadership. While people can be inconsistent in their stances, these primary source documents do show that while there was a mental acknowledgment of other tactics that could have ended the war, they weren't pursued at all. Rather, the article shows that the general thinking of the American leadership was that of atomic bombardment and its potential to limit the need for an amphibious landing. This can be seen by the fact that Truman wrote in a letter to his wife stating, "Say that we'll end the war a year sooner now, and think of the kids who won't be killed!", and that Truman also stated, "the bomb would make both an invasion and Soviet help unnecessary".⁴⁰

Overall, this analysis holds strong from a logical perspective. Despite clear evidence that figures like Stimson and Truman acknowledged the potential for ending the war through alternative means, they neither pursued these options nor made any genuine effort to explore what these alternatives could have achieved. By not fully considering or testing other strategies, such as a conditional surrender or the continued blockade, they missed an opportunity to potentially bring the war to a quicker and less devastating conclusion.

⁴⁰Gar Alperovitz, Robert L. Messer, "Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb," *International Security* 16, no. 3 (1991): 204, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539092>. Pp 208-209.

Another fallacy that the article addresses is the fact that the American leadership could have been in a situation where they faced an escalation of commitment fallacy where they invested an extensive amount of resources into a weapon that was increasingly becoming irrelevant and losing targets of detonation. Thus, it's not a large logical step to say that there was a cognitive bias that limited the ability of American leadership to choose another option.

As for the article by Sheldon Garon, they follow similar sources which were used by Christopher Clary by using the USSBS, in particular the *'The Japanese Wartime Standard of Living and Utilization of Manpower'*, as well as research conducted by the Navy War College, Air Force Historical Research Agency, and statements from Japanese notables. This does cause some issues on the reliability of the analysis as with the previous skepticism about the USSBS and the unreliability and inconsistency of post-war interviews with Japanese notables. Nonetheless, with the argument that is presented, there is an obvious strain that was being placed on the Japanese people from both the weather, which was causing poor harvest, and the blockade which was restricting the number of resources entering Japan. This is clear as there was a decrease in the mean amount of calories that were being consumed by the average Japanese citizen.⁴¹

However, the impact of this strategy on the decision to terminate the war remains inconclusive. The duration for which Japanese food stockpiles would have lasted is unclear, with data on the matter being inconclusive on both sides of the atomic argument. Additionally, there is no definitive timeline for when the war would have ended using this strategy. While Garon suggests that mass starvation, leading to an estimated seven million deaths within a year, would have pressured Japan to surrender, he provides no concrete evidence as to when the Japanese

⁴¹Garon, Sheldon. 2024. "Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan." *The International History Review* 46 (4): Pp 544.

high command would have capitulated before these casualties occurred.⁴² It's important to remember that President Truman's primary objective was to end the war as quickly as possible while minimizing American casualties. This strategy, while likely to have eventually led to the Japanese surrender, would not have met Truman's goal of a swift resolution. Therefore, while Garon's article offers substantial evidence that a surrender could have been achieved through a blockade, it is clear from his analysis that it would not have been the quickest or most effective strategy.

E. The Worth of Both Arguments

Both sides of this argument present objective facts to support their analysis and conclusions. While the USSBS's conclusions are somewhat questionable due to the biases of its director, this does not invalidate the document as a source. Both sides of the debate draw on it because of its comprehensive interviews and statistical data. Although the conclusions ultimately drawn from the USSBS may be misleading, the data it presents still holds value.

On the orthodox side of the atomic bomb debate, the arguments were primarily designed to undermine the legitimacy of claims that Truman had alternative options available that could have achieved better results. These arguments succeeded in creating doubt about the idea that the war would have ended as quickly without the use of the atomic bombs. This is evident in their critique of the USSBS, as well as their questioning of the blockade's effectiveness under Operation Starvation and the Japanese high command's position on surrender terms. Given President Truman's objective to end the war swiftly and minimize American casualties, it is reasonable to argue that he would have exhausted all possible means to achieve that goal. Including the deployment of an atomic bomb.

⁴²Garon, Sheldon. 2024. "Operation STARVATION, 1945: A Transnational History of Blockades and the Defeat of Japan." *The International History Review* 46 (4): Pp 546.

The revisionist argument raises a just concern about whether the loss of civilian lives was caused by the ineptitude or shortsightedness of decision-makers and whether those lives were ultimately wasted. In the context of the atomic debate, where outcomes are often framed in terms of probabilities, there is a decent chance that events like the blockade could have led Japan to surrender. While some of the assertions made within the blockade argument, such as the casualty count, may be exaggerated, there are valid points, like a weaker desire to fight and a weakened workforce, which would result from a starving population and army. However, the strongest argument made by the revisionists was the failure to pursue alternative means of peace that did not include the atomic bomb. It is clear that President Truman's strategy hinged on the success or failure of the atomic bombs, with his plans designed to accommodate both outcomes. This shortsightedness caused avenues such as a negotiated peace to be ruled out until after the failure of the bomb. This is particularly notable given that Truman and Stimson were both willing to allow Emperor Hirohito to remain on the throne and even considered adding that clause to the Potsdam Declaration, agreeing to it after Japan conceded to an unconditional surrender.

Conclusion

The decision to use atomic weapons against Japan in 1945 remains a highly debated topic. The orthodox view, supported by scholars like Robert P. Newman, Sadao Asada, and Christopher Clary, argues that the bombs were necessary to end the war quickly and save American lives, casting doubt on the likelihood of success for alternatives like negotiation and blockade. In contrast, revisionists such as Gar Alperovitz, Robert L. Messer, and Sheldon Garon contend that the escalation of commitment fallacy led President Truman to disregard viable alternatives, including a potential negotiated peace that both Truman and Japanese leaders might have accepted. Instead, Truman pursued atomic bombardment and insisted on unconditional

surrender. Revisionists also argue that military options like Operation Starvation, which would have caused minimal American casualties, were dismissed despite growing evidence that a blockade could have eventually forced Japan's surrender without the need for atomic bombs.

Ultimately, the decision Truman made to use atomic bombs was the one he believed to be in the best interest of the nation. In the deadliest conflict in history, Truman's primary concern was ending the war as quickly as possible, and his writings reflect this urgency. The lack of concrete evidence that a blockade would lead to Japan's capitulation, particularly given that its success might have taken up to a year, pushed Truman to pursue the alternative of atomic bombardment. However, Truman and other high-ranking American officials could have been more proactive in exploring diplomatic options to test the waters and confirm their suspicions about Japan's willingness to surrender once there was clear evidence they had been militarily defeated. The former conclusion on the probability of the success of the blockade comes from the fact that there was just too much conflicting data coming from the USSBS on whether Japan was able to survive starvation during the blockade. Keep in mind that both sides of the aisle used the USSBS as their main source in this matter. Furthermore, pursuing Operation Starvation, which involved a blockade, would have only prolonged the war, as blockades take time to show results and even longer to force surrender. A war that Truman had the expressed desire to conclude as fast as possible.

On the diplomatic front, probing for peace talks likely wouldn't have extended the war by a significant margin. There is clear evidence, including statements from Emperor Hirohito and Foreign Minister Togo, suggesting that Japan might have been willing to surrender under the condition that the Japanese imperial system be preserved. This was a condition the United States could have accepted, as the occupation force allowed for the continuation of the monarchy while

still achieving Japan's unconditional surrender. In conclusion, while the atomic bomb was a clear military choice to end the war efficiently, this doesn't preclude the possibility that diplomatic overtures should have been explored more thoroughly to achieve peace.

Bibliography

Alperovitz, Gar, Robert L. Messer. "Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb." *International Security* 16, no. 3 (1991): 204. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539092>.

Gar Alperovitz and Robert L. Messer are both highly credible scholars with extensive expertise in the fields of political economy, history, and military diplomacy. Alperovitz is a founding principal of The Democracy Collaborative, former Lionel R. Bauman Professor of Political Economy at the University of Maryland, and a well-known author of critically acclaimed works on the atomic bomb and atomic diplomacy. His broad academic and policy experience includes serving as a Fellow at prestigious

institutions like Kings College, Cambridge, and Harvard, as well as testifying before numerous congressional committees on issues related to nuclear policy. Messer, a historian with a Ph.D. from the University of California, Berkeley, has taught at the University of Illinois at Chicago for over three decades and published extensively on the history of World War II and the Cold War. His notable works include analyses of Truman's decision-making regarding the atomic bomb and the impact of U.S. foreign policy during the early Cold War. Both scholars draw on a combination of primary sources, including government documents, military reports, and scholarly consensus, to critically assess the historical significance of the atomic bombings. Alperovitz's use of the Strategic Bombing Survey and Messer's incorporation of Truman's correspondence and historical debates on the Cold War further solidify their authority and rigor in analyzing these pivotal historical events. Their scholarly contributions are grounded in a deep understanding of historical context, making them authoritative voices in the field.

Asada, Sadao. "The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan's Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration." *Pacific Historical Review* 67, no. 4 (November 1, 1998): 477–512. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3641184>.

Sadao Asada is a Professor Emeritus of Diplomatic History at Doshisha University in Kyoto, Japan, and an esteemed scholar in the field of Japanese-American relations and World War II history. Educated in the United States with a Ph.D. from Yale University, Asada is the author of Japanese-American Relations Between the Wars, which won the prestigious Yomiuri Yoshino Sakuzo Book Prize. His extensive scholarship has earned him the Edward S. Miller History Prize from the U.S. Naval War College and the Louis Knott Koontz Memorial Award from the American Historical Association. In his

article "The Shock of the Atomic Bomb and Japan's Decision to Surrender: A Reconsideration", Asada uses primary sources such as the diaries of Japanese leaders, government transcripts, and secondary works like Robert J. C. Butow's Japan's Decision to Surrender to critically reassess the role of the atomic bomb in Japan's decision to end the war. Asada's careful analysis of these sources provides a nuanced understanding of the internal deliberations and psychological impact on Japanese leadership, offering a fresh perspective on this pivotal moment in history. His expertise and scholarly rigor make this work a significant contribution to the field of diplomatic history and the study of World War II. Thus, he is credible.

Barnaby, Frank. "The Effects of the Atomic Bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki." *Medicine and War* 11, no. 3 (July 1995): 1–9. <https://doi.org/10.1080/07488009508409217>.

Frank Barnaby, a former nuclear physicist and consultant to the Oxford Research Group, was a prominent military author with over fourteen books on nuclear topics, including Nuclear Proliferation and the South African Threat. His career spanned from 1969 to 2016, and he also served as Director of the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute and a professor at the VU University in Amsterdam, granting him both nuclear expertise and credibility on conflict-related issues. In his work analyzing the effects of the atomic bombings, Barnaby utilized a blend of primary sources, including government reports, survivor testimonies, and medical studies, to examine the bombings' immediate and long-term consequences. His methodology incorporated historical analysis, statistical evaluation of casualty figures, and scientific research on health impacts, offering a comprehensive understanding of the devastating effects of nuclear warfare.

Barton J. Bernstein. "Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb." *International Security* 16, no. 3 (1991): 204. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539092>.

Barton J. Bernstein is a distinguished historian and Professor of History at Stanford University, renowned for his expertise in American foreign policy, nuclear history, and U.S. military strategy. After earning his Ph.D. in history from Harvard University, Bernstein became a leading voice in the study of the Truman administration and the history of the atomic bomb. His books include The Atomic Bomb, The Truman Administration: A Documentary History, and Towards a New Past: Dissenting Essays in American History. Bernstein has also written for influential publications such as Foreign Affairs, Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists, New York Review of Books, and Diplomatic History. In his seminal article "Marshall, Truman, and the Decision to Drop the Bomb", Bernstein critically examines the decision to use atomic weapons, drawing on a range of primary sources, including Japanese diplomatic transmissions and the diaries of key figures such as President Truman and Secretary of War Henry Stimson. Bernstein's careful analysis of these firsthand accounts provides a nuanced view of the internal debates and strategic considerations that shaped this pivotal moment in history. His scholarship, marked by his meticulous use of archival material, has made him a central figure in debates about U.S. military policy and the ethical dimensions of atomic warfare. As a member of the Board of Advisors for the Center on Peace and Liberty at the Independent Institute, Bernstein continues to contribute significantly to discussions on peace, liberty, and the history of American diplomacy. Through all of his research and expertise, he is credible.

Clary, Christopher. "The Starvation Myth: The U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II."

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Christopher Clary is an Associate Professor of Political Science whose research focuses on interstate rivalries, nuclear proliferation, U.S. defense policy, and South Asian politics. With a PhD from MIT and a distinguished career in both academia and government, including positions at the U.S. Department of Defense and the RAND Corporation, Clary brings a wealth of expertise to his work. In his article "The Starvation Myth: The U.S. Blockade of Japan in World War II", Clary challenges the widely-held belief that Japan faced imminent starvation due to the U.S. blockade in the final years of the war. Drawing on primary sources such as the United States Strategic Bombing Survey (USSBS) and direct quotations from Japanese leaders, Clary critically analyzes the actual impact of the blockade, demonstrating that Japan was far from facing mass starvation before the war ended. His careful use of these sources and his analytical approach provide a nuanced understanding of the blockade's true effects, offering valuable insights into U.S. wartime strategy and the geopolitical realities of the Pacific theater. He also sources a lot of work from another author, Newman, especially on his analysis of the USSBS. Nonetheless, his ability to have supporting claims from other credible sources and his ample resume allow him to be credible.

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Sheldon Garon is currently a Professor of History and East Asian Studies and a Nissan Professor in Japanese Studies at Princeton University. His publication started in 1987 with his book on the State and Labor in Modern Japan. He has other publications on the Second World War with emphasis on food shortages, blockades, and the histories of aerial bombardment. Altogether, I think Sheldon's elongated career in History, especially Japanese History, and current works about blockades and the warfare of the Second World War allow him to be a credible source on the topic. Their sources come from a variety of sources, from the Naval War College for operational plans to USSBS. There are also numerous sources from other articles, totaling 90 sources. Thus, this source is credible.

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*Geoffrey Giles is an Associate Professor of History whose research focuses on modern German history, the Holocaust, and the intersection of sexuality and politics in Nazi Germany. He received his Ph.D. in German history from the University of Cambridge and has taught at the University of Florida since 1978. Giles' extensive academic career includes notable publications such as his book *Students and National Socialism in Germany*, published by Princeton University Press, and numerous articles addressing topics ranging from Holocaust denial to the role of gender in Nazi ideology. In his research, Giles draws heavily on primary sources, particularly firsthand accounts from German citizens who lived through the hardships of World War I. The primary*

function that he serves within this article is to prove the existence of Turnip Winter within Germany, and with that purpose, he is credible.

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Robert P. Newman was a distinguished scholar and educator, widely recognized for his expertise in public argument, U.S. foreign policy, and military history. A professor emeritus at the University of Pittsburgh, Newman authored numerous influential works, including Evidence (1969) and Owen Lattimore and the "Loss" of China (1992), which received critical acclaim. In his article "Ending the War with Japan: Paul Nitze's Early Surrender", Newman applied his renowned analytical rigor to Paul Nitze's counterfactual exploration of Japan's potential early surrender in World War II. Drawing on testimonies and data from the United States Strategic Bombing Survey (USSBS), Newman critically assessed the strategic and diplomatic decisions that shaped the war's conclusion. With a career spanning over three decades, Newman was a pioneer in the field of communication and public argument, serving as Director of Graduate Studies at Pitt and receiving multiple prestigious awards, including the Winans-Wichelns Award for Distinguished Scholarship. His deep understanding of both the academic and practical dimensions of public debate, combined with his keen interest in historical analysis, made him a leading authority on military and foreign policy topics, further solidifying his legacy as a leading intellectual in the study of American history and argumentation.

Senat Fleury, Jean. *Pacific War*. S.l.: LAP LAMBERT ACADEMIC PUBL, 2023.

Jean Senat Fleury has the following academic credentials: Faculty of Law (Haiti), School of Magistrate (Paris-Bordeaux), Northeastern University (Boston, Massachusetts) (PRE-MBA), Suffolk University (Boston, Massachusetts) Political Science (Master degree), and Suffolk University (Boston, Massachusetts) Public Administration (Master degree). Jean also has around fifty books, ranging from the Second World War, with a specific preference towards the Pacific War, to other events such as the Russo-Japanese War. Both his decorated academic career and obvious devotion to Japanese history make him a credible source.